A History of Fury and Faith

with poems by Langston Hughes, Amanda Gorman and Joshua Sands

Mother to Son by Langston Hughes

(Pg 60) Well, son, I'll tell you:

Life for me ain't been no crystal stair.

It's had tacks in it,

And splinters,

And boards torn up,

And places with no carpet on the floor—

Bare.

But all the time

I'se been a-climbin' on,

And reachin' landin's,

And turnin' corners,

And sometimes goin' in the dark

Where there ain't been no light.

So boy, don't you turn back.

Don't you set down on the steps

'Cause you finds it's kinder hard.

Don't you fall now—

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For I'se still goin', honey,

I'se still climbin',

And life for me ain't been no crystal stair.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Langston Hughes
Book: The Collected Works of Langston Hughes, Volume 1, Pg 60
ISBN: 978-0826213396
Publisher: University of Missouri
Date (Month/Year): June 2001

INTRODUCTION

Equal opportunity has been the bedrock of American democracy, and our country's diversity one of our greatest strengths. But recently diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) programs have come under attack in American boardrooms, state legislatures – and now across the federal government. DEI has become a social and political lightning rod for those activists who feel such initiatives are unfair and even racist against white Americans. America, who do we want to be?

As Americans, do we value diversity and want to ensure that there is equity and inclusion for everyone . . . OR have we gone too far? Are unqualified women, immigrants, and people of color being given preferential treatment simply because of DEI efforts? I don't have the answers, but these poets may provide some insight into this quagmire of opposing thoughts . . .

A History of Fury and Faith containing Mother to Son by Langston Hughes, Faith and Fury by Amanda Gorman and An Abridged History of America by Joshua Sands

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Fury and Faith by Amanda Gorman

(Pg 153-157) You will be told this is not a problem,

Not ***your*** problem.

You will be told now is not the time

For change to begin,

Told that we cannot win.

But the point of protest isn't winning;

It's holding fast to the promise of freedom,

Even when fast victory is not promised.

Meaning, we cannot stand up to police

If we cannot cease policing our imagination,

Convincing our communities that this won't work,

When the work hasn't even begun,

That this can wait,

When we've already waited out a thousand suns.

By now, we understand

That white supremacy

& the despair it demands

Are as destructive as any disease.

So when you're told that your rage is reactionary,

Remind yourself that rage is our right.

It teaches us it is time to fight.

In the face of injustice,

Not only is anger natural, but necessary,

Because it helps carry us to our destination.

Our goal is never revenge, just restoration.

Not dominance, just dignity.

Not fear, just freedom.

Just justice . . .

When our fire can no longer be fueled by fury,

We will always be fortified by faith . . .

This is more than protest

It's a promise.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Amanda Gorman
Book: Call Us What We Carry, Pgs 153-157
ISBN: 978-0593465080
Publisher: Viking Books
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2024

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An Abridged History of America by Joshua Sands

(Pg 39-46) ***God bless America.***
Land that
I
love.
We set forth
for this
great
land
With beautiful English
ships,
English
money,
English
people.
We got settled with
English
help,
English food
shipments,
English medical
remedies.
We settled
and we spat on the
English,
shot the
English,
poured tea
on the English,
declared independence
from the
English.
Thanks
for the
memories, England.
Now leave.

We're comin' to America.

Indians treated
the land
with
respect.
So we shot
them,
raped them,
moved them
to five square
blocks south of
Phoenix, Arizona.
We'll even pay
the Indians
if they show
us a
raindance.
Entertain us –
We should celebrate

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Thanksgiving
by watching the
turkey with
it's head chopped
off.
Bleed and run.
Run and bleed.
We'll catch up to you.

OK – everyone squeeze in!
You can all fit, dammit.
Yes, those are all the names of
the people who went to Vietnam.
No, you can't visit them.
Now smile!

We purchased
Blacks from
Africa,
whipped them,
beat them,
kept them illiterate,
Called them 3/5
of a regular
American
(for census
purposes only).
Even when they were
"freed"

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they were uneducated,
scoffed at,
laughed at,
spat on.
Only now they
were homeless
and
hungry.
Thanks, Blacks,
For picking our
cotton.
We're warm.
Now,
go build
a
fire.

I'm confused who you Americans look up to.
Who do you respect in your country?
You mock your leader on talk shows
and impersonate him to create a cartoon.
Who do you look up to?
We have Nobel Prize winners, novelists,
Inventors, and political officials.
You have mistresses, lotto winners,
movie stars, and basketball players.

We fought some
wars for rightful

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causes:
Weird people
out there:
Stalin,
Hitler
beware.
Yet we were
and are
the only people
to drop an
A-Bomb on anyone.
And then do it again
for
emphasis.

I came to America to witness the future
I learned the language.
I brought my own money.
I came to America because they say it is the land of dreams.
I did not come to America to live here.
The street is not safe and I'm getting older.
I want to leave America, but have no money.
I want to leave America, but can't find directions.
On those carnival rides, they let you off when you get sick.
Please stop.
I want off.

We're homeless in America.

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The Blacks found a leader:
Martin Luther King.
so we
shot
him.
We found a leader:
JFK
so we
shot him.
Our leader had a brother:
Robert
so we
shot him, too
We found a singer:
John Lennon
and we shot
him, too
because we
were out of
leaders.

Buy American!
Don't let the Japanese take over!
The Japanese school day is roughly ten hours,
consisting of rigorous study
in the sciences,
languages,
composition,
mathematics,

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history.
The American school day is roughly six and one half hours,
consisting of the same subjects,
With recesses,
study halls,
club meetings,
and convocations mixed in.
The Japanese are ahead because they know mathematics:
six and a half mixed hours
do not equal
Ten quality hours.
But, still, buy American!

We went to war in Vietnam
Because it would
make us feel better.
People protested
the War
because it would
make them feel better.
People did drugs,
had free sex,
wore tie dye,
got shot.
In protest.
And it made them
geel better.

Estimated value of Beanie Baby: $800.

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Person who makes Beanie Baby: Annual income, $800.

I was told the other day that we donated over ten billion
dollars
to other countries in the name of
foreign relief.
This will improve their quality of living, or so I'm told.
I was told the other day that my son needs an operation.
I was told the other day that without it he will not survive.
I was told the other day to put up collection jars in the
community.
I was told the other day to pray.
The other day I prayed.
The other day I prayed for a miracle.
The other day I went to the grocery store and picked up
eight dollars
In loose change.
Today I will pray again.

We elected an actor
to be President –
so we wouldn't have
to train him
how to lie.
Besides,
he looked
good on TV.
And the Alzheimer's
jokes were funny

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later on
weren't they?
The Ayatollah took
hostages and we didn't
shoot him.
Castro was Satan;
we didn't
shoot him.
Saddam crossed the line
so we shot his people
and their children
but didn't shoot
him.

We sit in our
air-conditioned
condominium
with our Volvo's
and our e-mail
and voice mail
and cupboards full
of food
and *75* inch TV's
With 73 channels
and cordless phones
and power tools
and jet-skis
and mutual fund reports
and Guess watches

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and 2.5 kids and
a Dalmatian named
Spot.
And we say that
we deserve it
because we're
American.
And we buy it
Every time.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joshua Sands
Book: Turning Points, Pg 39-46
ISBN: 978-0742117013
Publisher: Tichenor Publishing
Date (Month/Year): 2001

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier – (this poem only)
2009 National Qualifier – (this poem only)
2010 National Qualifier – (this poem only)
2011 National Qualifier – (this poem only)
2019 National Qualifier – MS – (this poem only)
ND State Qualifier – (as a collection)

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